

Valéria Vieira dos Santos

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PROFESSIONAL PROFILE

PhD candidate in Linguistics (UFSCar, Brazil) working at the intersection of **computational pragmatics and Large Language Model evaluation**. My research investigates how the suppression of pragmatic markers (hesitations and disfluencies) affects **LLM calibration and hallucination behaviour**, using Brazilian Portuguese as a low-resource testbed. First-author of a paper accepted at **CODI-CRAC 2026 (ACL Anthology)** and four additional peer-reviewed venues. Six years of applied NLP experience designing production conversational AI for clients including Netflix, Claro and Globoplay.

RESEARCH INTERESTS

LLM evaluation, calibration and hallucination detection · Computational pragmatics in dialogue · Disfluencies and spontaneous speech in NLP · Low-resource NLP for Brazilian Portuguese · Explainable AI in Social NLP.

PUBLICATIONS & PRESENTATIONS

- **Santos, V. V.** (2026). Speech Disfluencies and LLM Calibration: A Pilot Study on the Effects of Textual Sanitization in Brazilian Portuguese. *Proceedings of the 7th Workshop on Computational Models of Discourse, Dialogue, and Cross-Document Coreference (CODI-CRAC 2026)*, San Diego, USA. ACL Anthology. **[Accepted; camera-ready May 2026]**
- **Santos, V. V.** (2026). Preserving Pragmatic Integrity: How the Suppression of Hesitation Markers Affects Epistemic Modality and Trust in LLMs. *HUMIC Symposium: Humans and Machines in Conversation*, University of Surrey, UK. **[Spoken presentation; PGR Free Registration Grant]**
- **Santos, V. V.** (2026). Extracting Behavioral Patterns from Conversational Data: A Comparative Study of Human and AI Hesitation for Knowledge Management. *Proceedings of LPKM 2026*. **[Accepted]**
- **Santos, V. V.** & Malaga, M. (2025). A Methodology for Prompt Engineering in Engineering: Framework Development and Performance Evaluation. *Proceedings of the Industrial Engineering 2025 Conference*, University of West Bohemia, Plzeň, Czech Republic. ISBN 978-80-261-1328-7. [\[Link\]](#)
- **Santos, V. V.** (2025). Hesitação e Humanização em Chatbots: Uma Análise Linguística. *Linguasagem*, 43(1). ISSN 1983-6988. [\[Link\]](#)

AWARDS & GRANTS

- **PGR Free Registration Grant**, HUMIC Symposium, University of Surrey (2026) — competitive grant for post-graduate researchers.
- **Master's Thesis distinction**, GPA 3.8/4.0, Federal University of São Carlos (2025).

RESEARCH PROJECTS

PhD Research — LLM Calibration & Hallucination Federal University of São Carlos (UFSCar) · 2025 – Present

Investigating the correlation between the suppression of pragmatic markers (hesitations) and semantic hallucinations in LLMs (GPT-4, Sabiá-2). Building a contrastive benchmark on the **Roda Viva Corpus** (Brazilian Portuguese spontaneous speech) to audit overconfidence through **Expected Calibration Error (ECE)** and semantic-entropy metrics. Pilot study published at CODI-CRAC 2026. Open-source code: github.com/ValeriaVSantos/uncertainty-signature-audit.

Visiting Research Intern — Prompt Engineering for LLMs University of West Bohemia, Czech Republic · Jan – Apr 2025

Conducted research on Prompt Engineering methodology to evaluate the suitability and accuracy of LLMs in specialised technical tasks. Connected linguistic methodologies with engineering terminology; co-authored a peer-reviewed publication (Industrial Engineering 2025 Conference).

Master's Thesis — Hesitation in Human-Machine Dialogue

UFSCar · 2023 – 2025

Modelled hesitation as a pragmatic marker shaping perceived “humanness” and coherence in human-machine dialogue, with implications for relational effectiveness in conversational AI. Thesis: repositorio.ufscar.br.

EDUCATION

2025 – Present	PhD in Linguistics , Federal University of São Carlos (UFSCar), Brazil.
2026 – Present	Specialisation in Applied Statistics , Anhanguera. Focus: quantitative methods and statistical modelling for NLP.
2023 – 2025	M.A. in Linguistics , Federal University of São Carlos (UFSCar). GPA 3.8/4.0.
2015 – 2018	B.A. in Linguistics , Federal University of São Carlos (UFSCar).

INDUSTRY EXPERIENCE (APPLIED NLP)

AI Project Manager — Serasa Experian, São Paulo, Brazil	Aug 2022 – Aug 2025
– Led the design and deployment of large-scale conversational AI systems (virtual assistants, chatbots), migrating customer-service channels from 80% voice to 70% digital and reaching CSAT 4.7. – Owned linguistic data strategy: intent and entity taxonomies, training corpora curation, NLU error analysis and continuous evaluation of NLP pipelines.	
Conversational Intelligence Coordinator / Chapter Lead — Blip, Belo Horizonte, Brazil	Aug 2021 – Aug 2022
– Led multidisciplinary squads building NLP-driven AI agents for Netflix, Claro and Globoplay on the Blip platform. – Defined intent/entity schemas, curated and validated training corpora, and standardised dialogue-design guidelines across products.	
Founder / Conversational AI Specialist — Langue, São Carlos, Brazil	2018 – 2021
– Founded a boutique conversational AI consultancy: bespoke chatbot and voicebot solutions for SMEs across the full project lifecycle (design, deployment, evaluation).	

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant (Paid Facilitator), Distance Education — UNIVESP / UFSCar partnership	Feb 2026 – Present
– Mediation, assessment and student support in the Virtual Learning Environment; 12 hours/week dedicated to teacher-training pedagogy.	
Supervised Teaching Internship (PESCD) — UFSCar	2025
– Co-taught an undergraduate Linguistics laboratory (“Lab 8”): delivered a full lecture, supported students in weekly assignments and participated in course design.	

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Programming	Python (advanced) — Pandas, NumPy, Matplotlib, Seaborn, Jupyter. Bash, Git/GitHub, L ^A T _E X.
NLP / ML	Hugging Face Transformers, PyTorch, spaCy, NLTK, scikit-learn. Hands-on experience with GPT-4, Sabiá-2 and BERT-family models for evaluation tasks.
LLM Evaluation	Expected Calibration Error (ECE), semantic entropy, NLI-based hallucination metrics, contrastive benchmarking, prompt engineering.
Statistical Analysis	Statsmodels, SciPy — hypothesis testing, regression, distributional analysis for NLP experiments.
Conversational AI	Dialogflow, Rasa, Microsoft Bot Framework, Blip platform; intent/entity design, NLU evaluation, dialogue management.
Open-source	uncertainty-signature-audit (PhD pilot, CODI-CRAC 2026); regras-de-qualidade-de-texto (automatic text-quality analysis).

LANGUAGES

Portuguese (native) · English (fluent) · Spanish (advanced) · French (intermediate).

REFERENCES

Prof. Dr. Oto Araújo do Vale	PhD Thesis Advisor, UFSCar — otovale@ufscar.br
Prof. Ing. Miroslav Malaga, Ph.D.	Visiting Research Supervisor, University of West Bohemia — malaga@kpv.zcu.cz
Renato Ciccarelli	Customer Care Director, Serasa Experian — renato.ciccarelli@experian.com